had charged Rs 1 lakh for Sasi.

I did not have that kind of money. My brother-in-law Arunachalam said they would borrow money to pay the lawyer. I told Shankar to get money from my colleague Mohana Prasad, who was also my neighbour or from Isaac, another friend. But I told them not to hire an expensive lawyer. Shankar and Arunachalam came one day with news.

Sankar insisted that we move through advocate Nair. I agreed, but with the condition that we would not pay the lawyer Rs 1 lakh. Nair finally got me bail, and charged only Rs 25,000. When Sasi came to know of this later, he was cribbing about the lawyer having charged him four times what he took from me. I asked Sasi if he was unhappy that he paid more or because I paid less.

After fifty days in captivity, including twenty-seven days in prison, I was to be released on bail on 19 January 1995.

IN THE PSLV WORKSHOP

'We are making a rocket, and the Americans are not happy about it.'

We returned from Vernon jubilant after the Vikas ground test, but there was no time to waste in celebration. The team plunged into work, now that our task was cut out. We had to put together an engine for the first PSLV flight, which was planned in another five years.

PSLV, then finalised as a four-stage rocket, would have Vikas, the sixty-tonne thrust liquid engine powering the second stage. The first and third stages were of solid propulsion, the fourth was to have another liquid engine of almost one-tenth the thrust of Vikas.

This smaller engine was developed by a team headed by K Sivaramakrishnan Nair and C G Balan who did some remarkable, yet not so celebrated work. Though small, this engine that worked on the regenerative cooling technique had its own intricacies that include use of fuel also as a